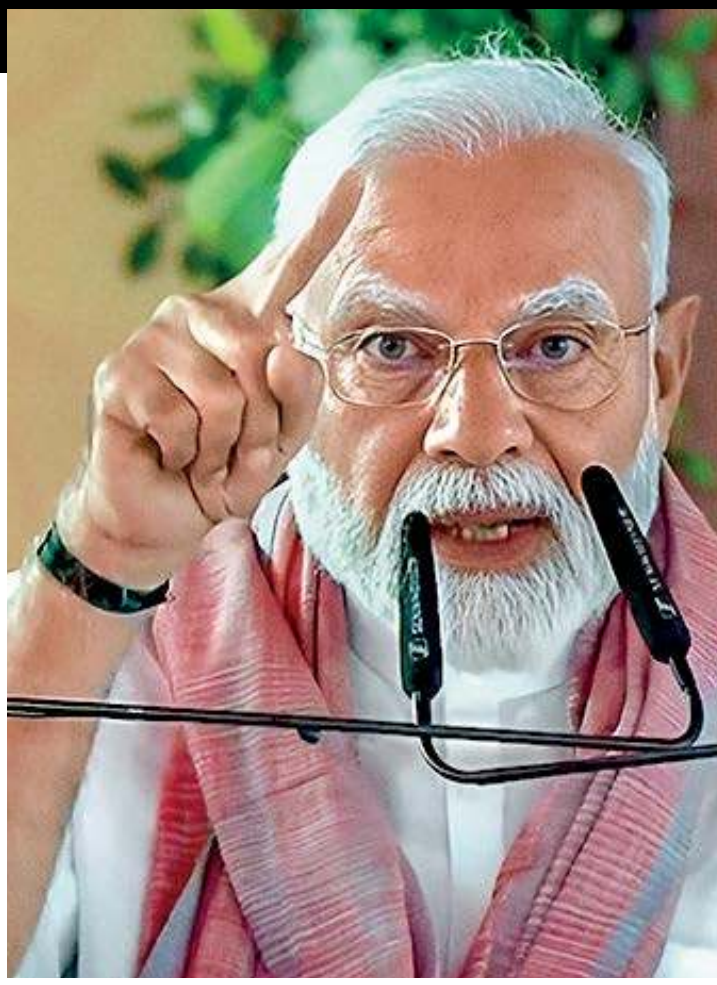
Vinay Narwal, a 26-year-old lieutenant in the Indian Navy, and his wife, Himanshi, had been really looking forward to their dream honeymoon in idyllic Pahalgam after they failed to get a visa for Switzerland. They had flown into Kashmir soon after their wedding reception in Karnal, Haryana. The next day, on April 22, they joined hundreds of other tourists to visit the alpine meadows of Baisaran. "We never thought this trip would turn into a nightmare," recounted a dazed and teary-eyed Himanshi, her hands still adorned with henna and the bridal *chura* (bangles). "I was eating bhelpuri with my husband," she is heard telling locals in a video. "A man came over and asked my husband if he was Muslim. When he said no, the man shot him dead." Screams filled the meadow as 26 human lives were taken with that same suddenness, on that merest pretext, in the space of a few unending minutes. Soon after, a photographer captured the distraught Himanshi seated beside her slain husband with blood stains on her clothes, framing the horror for a nation. The next day, when Vinay's body was flown to his hometown for cremation, Himanshi broke down before his coffin, draped in the national flag. "I pray that his soul is in peace, and he has the best time wherever he is," she managed to say through her tears.

These haunting, heart-wrenching scenes played out across the country as the coffins of the others slain in the Pahalgam attack came home for their last rites. The brutal killing of innocent tourists in Kashmir, the worst terror attack on civilians in the Valley in over two decades, forced Prime Minister Narendra Modi to cut short his official visit to Saudi Arabia and return to New Delhi. But not before posting a stern message on X: "Those behind this heinous act will be brought to justice...they will not be spared! Their evil agenda will never succeed." On his return, the prime minister immediately convened a session of the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS), which included home minister Amit Shah, defence minister Rajnath Singh, external affairs minister S. Jaishankar and finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman. They were briefed about the cross-border linkages of the terror attack with Pakistan.



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The question then arose of what was to be done. A range of steps presented themselves as options before New Delhi—and each may finally find its own time and space. As an instantaneous punitive measure, foreign secretary Vikram Misri announced that the CCS had decided to suspend the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT) of 1960 with immediate effect, until, as he put it, "Pakistan credibly and irrevocably abjures its support for cross-border terrorism." The 65-year-old treaty, which has survived four wars between the two countries, allots the eastern rivers of the Indus system—the Sutlej, Beas and Ravi—for India's unrestricted use. Pakistan receives much of the waters from the western rivers—the Indus, Jhelum and Chenab. The treaty decrees that any move by New Delhi to alter the flow of the rivers through dams or other means needs to be negotiated with Islamabad.

India had threatened to revoke the IWT after the 2019 Pulwama attacks as well, but stopped short of executing the threat. It did reiterate its intention to do so in September 2024, though, when it sought a "review and modification" of the treaty. However, by suspending the treaty now, with stringent clauses for reinstatement, India is shutting the door completely. The move holds serious implications for Pakistan's water security, especially in the populous and politically powerful provinces of Punjab and Sindh. While the